was afoot. ‘A messenger who I had sent into the town to make some trifling purchases, returned breathless, in the greatest state of excitement, reporting that the shops were all closed, and crowds of armed men were filling the streets?. . .’ he recorded. ‘I instantly rose and sought the Envoy, whom I found at about eight am in earnest consultation with General Elphinstone?. . .’[4]

Lawrence proposed that the 5,000 British troops in the cantonment should be marched immediately into the city to Burnes’s residence and that the two known ringleaders of the uprising, Aminullah Khan Logari and Abdullah Khan Achakzai, should both be arrested: ‘Not a moment should be lost!’ But, as he wrote later, ‘my proposal was at once put down as one of pure insanity and, under the circumstances, utterly unfeasible’. A second proposal was, however, accepted: that the recently married garrison engineer, Lieutenant Sturt, should gallop out to Brigadier Shelton, who was encamped on the far side of the city at Siyah Sang guarding the route into the city from the mouth of the disturbed Khord Kabul Pass. Sturt should tell him about the mob marauding around Pul-i-Khishti and encourage him to march to the Bala Hisar fort; from there he could command the walled city and take appropriate action. Lawrence was meanwhile to head on to the Bala Hisar and confirm the plan with Shah Shuja.

With a small escort of four troopers, Lawrence set off from the cantonment at around 9 a.m., directing his escort ‘to keep close up to me, to use their spurs if necessary, but on no account to pull up or stop’.

> Near the fort of Mahomed Khan, an Affghan rushed from a ditch on to the road, brandishing a huge double-handed sword, and made a furious lunge at me, which I avoided by throwing my stick at him, drawing my sword and making my horse plunge towards him. One of my escort killed the fellow with a shot from his carbine . . . Just as we emerged from the road we were met by a shout and a rapid fire of musketry from a second party of men concealed in a ditch. Our rapid pace, and the firing being too high, alone saved us from destruction.

When he got to the Bala Hisar, Lawrence was conducted into the presence of the Shah, ‘who was walking with great agitation up and down the court’.

> His Majesty exclaimed, ‘Is this not just what I always told the Envoy would happen, if he would not follow my advice?’ I then informed the King of the object of my visit, and requested His Majesty to authorise me to order up Brigadier Shelton’s brigade to occupy the Bala Hisar. ‘Wait a little,’ the King replied. ‘My son Fatteh Jang, and the Prime Minister, Usman Khan [Nizam al-Daula], have gone down into the city and with some of my troops. I have no doubt they will suppress the tumult.’[5]